

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Developing Leadership Styles

Choose the Right Style for the Situation

Lead with Policy when:

- ☐ The decision recurs frequently
- ☐ Many people must make the decision consistently
- ☐ Speed and predictability matter
- ☐ You want the organization to move without you in the room

Lead with Consensus when:

- ☐ Multiple stakeholders hold a critical context
- ☐ No one person has the full picture
- ☐ The decision is important enough to remember in 6 months
- ☐ Buy-in materially affects execution
- ☐ The issue isn't well-suited for policy

Lead with Conviction when:

- ☐ The decision is high-stakes and long-lasting
- ☐ Stakeholders are deeply divided
- ☐ No one has clear authority or a full context
- ☐ The decision is unlikely to be repeated

- ☐ Momentum is stalled, and someone must decide

Style Execution Checklists

Leading with Policy

- ☐ Identify a frequently recurring decision
- ☐ Study how strong decision-makers handle it today
- ☐ Codify the best judgment into a clear written policy
- ☐ Validate with key contributors
- ☐ Roll it out intentionally
- ☐ Set a review point to revisit with data
- ☐ Iterate as needed

Leading from Consensus

- ☐ Confirm the decision needs broad input
- ☐ Identify all relevant stakeholders
- ☐ Create a shared communication channel
- ☐ Write a framing document outlining known perspectives
- ☐ Ensure everyone feels heard
- ☐ Appoint the most senior engaged leader
- ☐ Set a clear deadline
- ☐ Follow the agreed decision-making process
- ☐ Close the loop and communicate the outcome

Leading with Conviction

- ☐ Confirm that the decision is important and non-recurring
- ☐ Deeply understand the trade-offs
- ☐ Engage the individuals with the most context

- ☐ Write down your reasoning
- ☐ Pressure-test your thinking
- ☐ Communicate a tentative decision with a short timeout
- ☐ Finalize and move to execution
- ☐ Document the rationale for transparency

Micromanagement Self-Check

Ask yourself:

- ☐ Am I carefully considering feedback from those closest to the work?
- ☐ Am I adding friction to a team that would reach a similar outcome without me?

If:

- ☐ ✓ Yes to the first
- ☐ ✓ No to the second
→ You're likely not micromanaging.

Development Checklist

- ☐ Identify which style you default to
- ☐ Identify which style you underuse
- ☐ Once a month, review upcoming decisions
- ☐ Choose one to intentionally handle using your weaker style
- ☐ Debrief with someone skilled in that style
- ☐ Compare outcomes vs. your default approach
- ☐ Repeat consistently

Balance & Engagement Check

- ☐ Am I defaulting to one style out of habit?
- ☐ Has my company context changed (growth, downturn, scale)?
- ☐ Am I too distant from details?
- ☐ Am I over-engaging unnecessarily?
- ☐ Is my role currently too challenging or not challenging enough?

Core Principle Reminder

- ☐ You can misuse any leadership style
- ☐ No single style works everywhere
- ☐ Strong executives develop fluency in all three
- ☐ The goal is adaptability, not purity